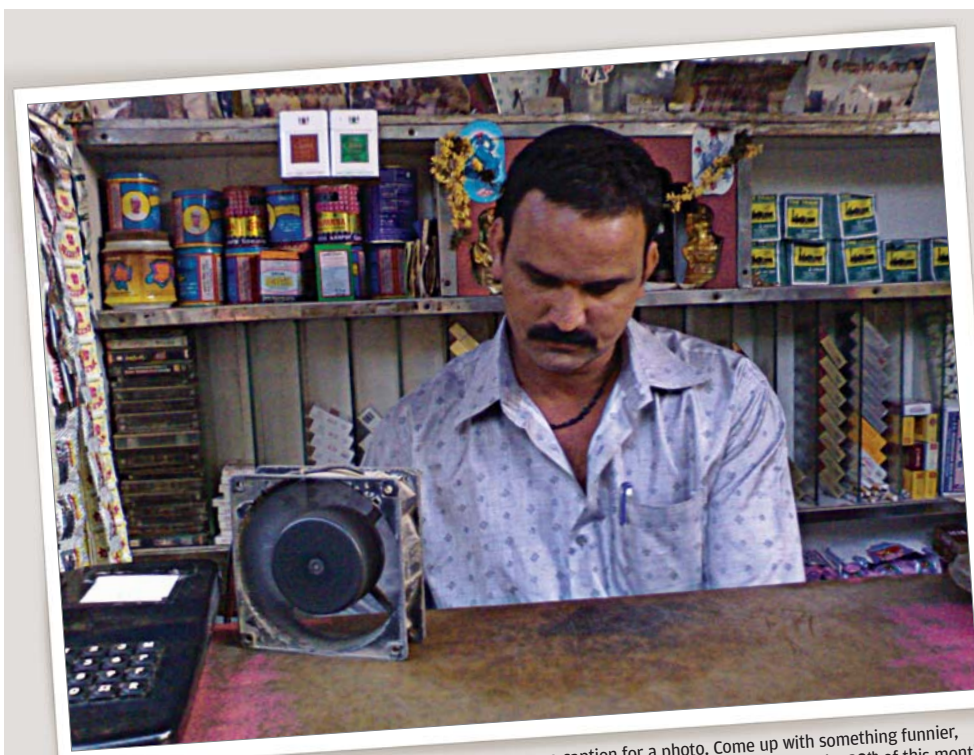




Photograph Yashraj D. Pawar

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research firm emedia. 65 per cent said they use SN sites for business networking; 58 per cent said SN sites were a platform for exchanging ideas. Other uses included research and getting advice. Of course, the biggest use remains (this wasn't revealed by the survey, but we can guess) things like chatting, making new friends... you know.

Now here's the interesting data: a whopping 62 per cent of those surveyed said they worry, for the reasons we've mentioned, about the security of the sites and the safety of their personal data. About a third said they submit false information. So here's a question for that 33 per cent: if hackers and employers are making you paranoid and insecure, why use the sites... why pretend to be who you're not, like on just any IM or chat-room? Isn't the point of SN sites to network like in the real world?

Social networking sites have a lesson to learn from

this. They've already degraded a little into being something like chat-rooms, and they need to make sure the downslide doesn't continue. How?

Consider this. Facebook, for example, asks you to verify your relationship with someone you claim to know. So when you say you went to school with someone, that someone has to approve of that information you submit. You can't just say you lived with someone when you didn't. Now along the same lines, how about when someone does a search on you... can't the sites ask you for permission before they reveal any details about you? "Ms X tried to click on your profile. Allow?"

The sites could take a cue from Amazon's "Real Name" system, where you submit your credit card number to verify you are who you say you are. Such members of, say, a site with only over-16 members, could give out badges for "verified real" members. And then, they'd need to keep that

information secure, with stringent privacy policies.

Sounds totalitarian, but it could be very utilitarian. No-one wants to be cheated online when it comes to identities. Something needs to be done before SN sites get down to the level of casual virtual hangouts.

BUSINESS AS USUAL

Storage Gets Sexier

New things are happening and un-happening on the storage front, and here's a wrap-up of the latest news—because we haven't done one such in a long time now.

First, researchers from the National Physical Laboratory in the UK have conceived of an entirely new hard disk read head mechanism. To cut a long story short, the magnetic field of the bit on the platter induces a change in the resistance of the read

head, which is measured. And the structure that allows for the measurement is relatively large—and thus far, there seems to be no way to make it smaller. If the read heads aren't made smaller, the bits can't be placed closer together on the platter. The news is that the read head structure *can* be simplified. If that happens, the new technology could provide a two-fold increase in storage density. And thus marches on the doubling-of-storage-density-every-year.

Then comes news from the nanotech scene: new research on nanowires points—yet again—to high-density, non-volatile storage. Researchers have long been exploring "phase changes" as a method for storing data: discrete points in a crystalline material are heated and rapidly cooled to make the material amorphous. (That's the phase change—between crystalline and amorphous.) Now, researchers at the University of Pennsylvania have constructed a memory